GUNBOAT IMPERIALISM

THE TRADITION OF "sending in a gunboat" to intimidate a non-European state was established by Britain in its first Opium War with China from 1839 to 1842. The flat-hulled steam-powered iron boats became a symbol of European imperialism because of their unique effectiveness in penetrating Asian or African rivers and coastal waters that otherwise might have offered some shelter from European naval power. Yet it was the overall strength of their fleets, rather than any specific type of vessel, that allowed Britain and France in particular to project power on a global scale in the 19th century. By using their navies, these imperialist European states could often achieve their objectives by limited punitive actions, without the need for costly campaigns of conquest. Non-European countries sometimes courageously resisted intimidation—the reverse suffered by the British at the hands of the Chinese at the Dagu forts in 1859 was a reminder that the outcome of battle was never inevitable. But most encounters were one-sided, European fleets crushing technologically inferior opposition with arrogant and ruthless efficiency.



The Nemesis
The experimental gunboat *Nemesis* (far right) destroys a Chinese war junk with a Congreve rocket in Anson's Bay, 1841. Also armed with 32lb and 6lb guns, she played an outstanding part in the reduction of China's defenses during the First Opium War.

FIRST OPIUM WAR

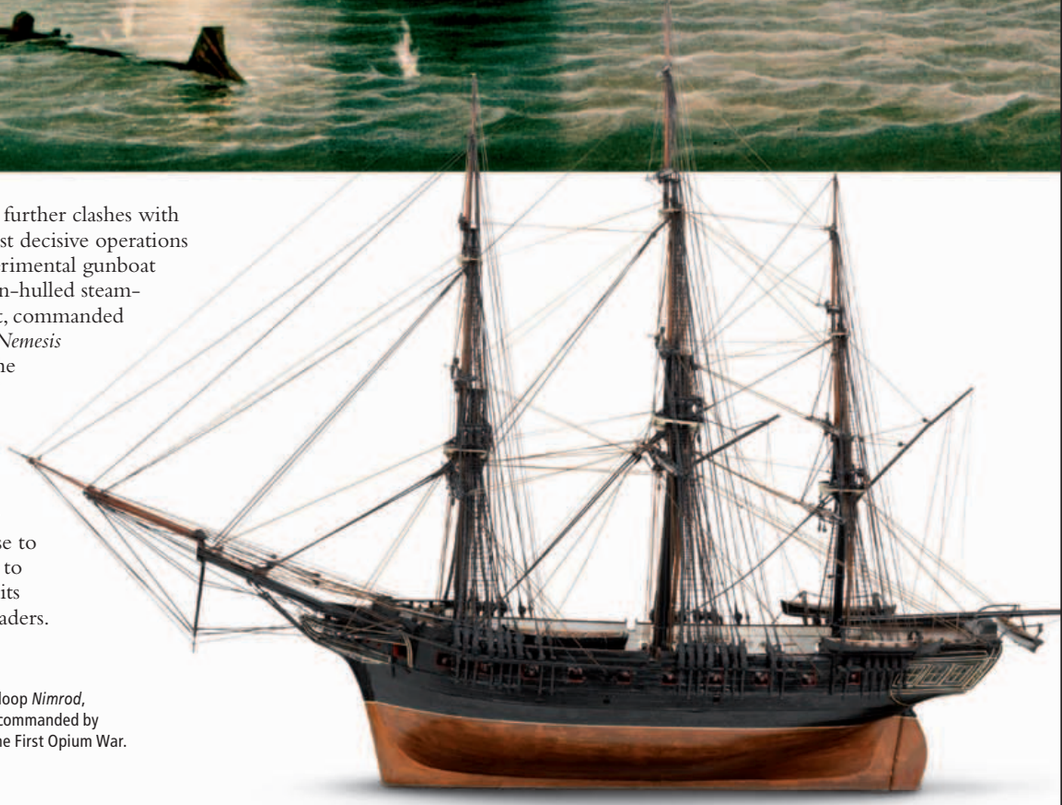
FIRST OPIUM WAR



Date 1839–1842
Forces British: 16 sailing ships, 4 steam ships, 1 iron gunboat; Chinese: unknown.
Losses Unknown

Location
Southern China

In November 1839, tensions arose between the British East India Company and Chinese officials, who were attempting to stop the import of opium through Canton (Guangzhou). This led to open hostilities when Chinese war junks exchanged fire with the frigate *Volage* and sloop *Hyacinth*. The British government sent a force of warships and troop transports to blockade Canton and other Chinese ports. There were further clashes with junks, but the most decisive operations involved the experimental gunboat *Nemesis*. A flat iron-hulled steam-driven paddleboat, commanded by William Hall, *Nemesis* could negotiate the shallow waters of Chinese rivers, landing troops and bombarding strongpoints. Defeat in the war forced the Chinese to cede Hong Kong to Britain and open its ports to British traders.



HMS Nimrod
The 18-gun sixth-rate sloop *Nimrod*, launched in 1828, was commanded by Joseph Pearse during the First Opium War.